

achievements at the top level. But it would be a mistake to count him out based on the past, as many did after Alonso's appointment at Leverkusen. Making the unthinkable possible and scripting surprises is football's strongest forte, and that is what makes it the beautiful game.

It is difficult to be hopeful if you are a Borussia Dortmund fan, given the countless disappointments over the years that saw the club fail to win a major title.

Ahead of next season, with Leverkusen's dominance and Bayern's hunger to get back on top, Dortmund will need to exceed expectations to even think of a title challenge — and will have to do so without the services of loyal servant Marco Reus, who decided to leave the club after 12 years.

FC St. Pauli and Holstein Kiel will be the promoted teams in the Bundesliga next season.

Serie A

Some say Italian football is now what the Premier League used to be — unpredictable as to who will become champion.

After years of dominance by Juventus, Inter became the first to break its stronghold by grabbing the Scudetto in the 2020-21 season. Since then, Milan has returned into the fray, tasting success.

One cannot forget Napoli's fairytale season, which saw it win the title in the 2022-23 season after a long wait of 33 years since the era of Diego Maradona.

Last season, Inter, under the guidance of Simone Inzaghi, was the runaway champion, finishing 19 points above runner-up and rival Milan.

However, going by recent trends, Inter is unlikely to have such a dominant season again. It will face a stern challenge from Milan and Juventus, both of whom will have new head coaches in Paulo Fonseca and Thiago Motta, respectively.

Also, the incomings and outgoings during the transfer window will be a

Top transfers



Kylian Mbappé

PSG to Real Madrid — Free transfer

Julián Álvarez

Manchester City to Atletico Madrid — **£82m**

Dani Olmo (right)

RB Leipzig to Barcelona — **£46m** plus add-ons

Endrick

Palmeiras to Real Madrid — **£40m** plus add-ons

Riccardo Calafiori

Bologna to Arsenal — **£33.6m** plus add-ons

Joao Neves

Benfica to PSG — **£50m** plus add-ons

Matthijs de Ligt

Bayern Munich to Manchester United — **£42.9m**

determining factor in how the top teams fare next season, and a clearer picture will emerge once the window closes. Parma, Como, and Venezia will be the newly promoted clubs in Serie A next season.

Ligue 1

Mbappé's departure from French top-flight football is a loss not only for PSG but for the league, at least in terms of popularity and viewership. However, PSG president Nasser Al-Khelaifi has strongly maintained that his team will succeed without the star Frenchman, despite the seemingly sour relations after an unceremonious exit and monetary disputes, with Mbappé claiming he is still owed a fair share by the French champion.

Ligue 1 has mostly been a one-horse race over the years, and while PSG would want to remain the

best team in France, it wouldn't be surprising if head coach Luis Enrique prioritises the UEFA Champions League — a crown that the club has yet to win and with the victory high on the agenda. To help make the UCL dream a reality, PSG has made a statement by signing Portuguese midfielder João Neves from Benfica.

This might pave the way for other clubs to mount a title challenge and repeat Lille's heroics from the 2020-21 season when it pipped PSG to the title.

Last season, runner-up Monaco looked in fine shape before eventually falling away and will look to launch a similar title challenge along with the likes of Brest, Lille, and perennial challenger Lyon.

Aj Auxerre, Angers SCO, and 10-time champion AS Saint-Étienne will be the newly promoted teams next season in Ligue 1.



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